



World-class: Though he made just two appearances for France at the FIFA U-17 World Cup in India, Aurelien Tchouameni has since blossomed into one of world football's premier midfielders. GETTY IMAGES

His equaliser against the Netherlands, however, cannot be separated from the man who has supplied him throughout almost every stage of his international career.

"It was moving," Nakamura said after scoring from another Takefusa Kubo assist against the Netherlands. "My first goal for the senior national team was also from Kubo's pass, and today again he assisted me. We've

played together since our youth days. In certain situations, I know the pass is coming without us saying anything."

It is a partnership that has evolved over almost a decade.

In Guwahati, during Japan's opening match of the 2017 FIFA U-17 World Cup, Nakamura scored a first-half hat-trick in a 6-1 victory over Honduras. His first goal came from a Kubo corner before Kubo added one

of his own before half-time.

Nine years later, the script remains familiar.

Against the Netherlands, Kubo burst into the left side of the penalty area before cutting the ball back into what Japanese media have long called the 'Keito Zone', an area where Nakamura has been lethal since his days at the Mitsubishi Yowa youth academy.

But Kubo and Nakamura's journey